Graphic Design

Portfolio creation in InDesign

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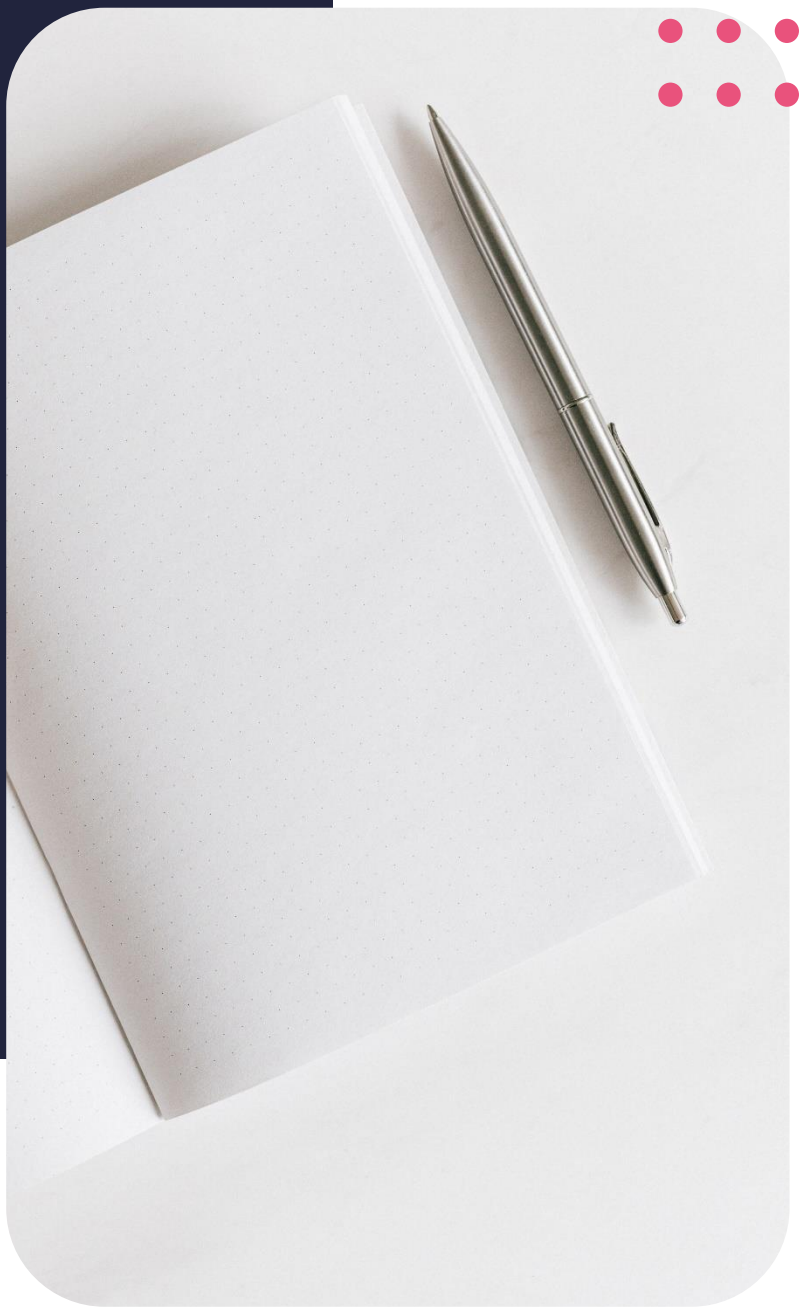

Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Define a graphic design portfolio
- Tips for creating your portfolio
- Portfolio creation

Practical lesson outcome:

Create your very own graphic design portfolio. You can make use of the technique learnt in this lesson, or any other means by adding it to portfolio websites, creating your own website or even printing it out, if you are up to it.

Introduction

A solid graphic design portfolio is your key to becoming a successful graphic designer. It showcases your design skill and ability allowing you vast opportunities within the design realm. At the end of the day, your portfolio will leave the last impression. It is therefore crucial to understand what to add to your portfolio, how much to add and also how to present this portfolio. Your portfolio should speak for itself, without you needing to explain what is being showcased.

Quoting Steve Jobs, this motivation can be applied to anything in your life; if you are working on something that you really care about, you don't have to be pushed. The vision pulls you."

We will focus on creating your own design portfolio by first understanding what a graphic design portfolio is. Then, I will share with you some great advice that will assist you in making a show-stopper portfolio. This lesson will end with a demo on creating your own portfolio with InDesign.

Define a graphic design portfolio

A portfolio and specifically a graphic design portfolio is a means to showcase your talent, skill and experience to potential employers, clients or other parties who might be interested in your services. An effective design portfolio has the potential to expose you to many opportunities. Therefore, this might be one of the most important tasks that you will tackle as a designer.

In essence, a portfolio embodies the skills and experience of a designer. It is a document encapsulating a designer's best work, whether the portfolio is printed or in digital format. This portfolio is your way of marketing yourself to clients or potential employers.

Why is a portfolio important?

Looking at why a portfolio is so important; I don't think I really need to explain this to you. Graphic design, being a form of visual communication entails that your customer or audience view elements to convey a message from that. The purpose is normally advertising, or marketing driven. So, in essence, a portfolio is your visual representation of your identity as a designer, it is how you advertise yourself to your client or a potential employer.

Where to get inspiration?

One of the most difficult tasks when it comes to creating a portfolio is to get started. What do you add and where should it feature? How do you add it and why do you want to add it? We will get into more detail explaining this a bit later, but for some inspiration I can recommend you have a look at these websites. You can see what other professional designers are up to and get some inspiration.

Dribbble is a social media platform used by creatives to share their work. You can build your portfolio and get in touch with potential clients.

Behance, also a social media platform is owned by Adobe. It serves the same function as Dribbble in that it showcases your work to potential clients and also other creatives.

Abduzeedo, or ABDZ is a blog on design and creative articles written by professionals, covering topics like Photography, UI/UX and web design.

Awwwards, is a website where awards are given for the purpose of celebrating excellent design, creativity, innovation and so on. This websites consists of some of the best designers the world has to offer.

Pinterest is like the mood board of the internet. The most common reason people make use of Pinterest is to be inspired, find new ideas, see what designers, illustrators and creatives are up to and apply these concepts to their own designs. I am sure that you know what Pinterest is. If you don't have a Pinterest account, I would suggest you get one.

Showcasing your work

Considering all you have learnt; it would make sense to have your work be showcased somewhere. In the old days, graphic designers as well as other type of designers including fashion designers, interior designers and even architects made use of physical portfolios they carried around with them. Today, we have different means of showcasing our work, including the good-old-fashioned physical portfolio, which can be quite expensive, especially if you need to update it on a regular basis, but we also have digital means.

There are three digital means that you should be aware of include loading your designs to a portfolio-based site, as we have just been introduced to.

Secondly, creating your own website. If you have the means and knowledge, you can create a great looking website. Then, creating your own pdf portfolio to either upload or email to potential customers or employees. In today's demo, we will demonstrate the ability to create your own interactive pdf portfolio.

Did you know?

Did you know that the Nike (nikey) logo is referred to as the Nike swoosh and was created for a mere $35 back in 1971 by student Carolyn Davidson. The logo’s inspiration was based on the Greek goddess of victory, called Nike and it resembled a wing that symbolised movement.

Tips for creating a portfolio

The next step after you have found inspiration to your portfolio, is creating it. Based on the research and references you have gathered; you will work according to a theme.

I personally prefer to make use of the same theme that my résumé and CV is created in to create a sense of uniformity. Also, remember that it can be quite difficult to create a theme, especially if you need to do it for yourself. I don't know about you, but one of the most difficult tasks for me as a graphic designer was coming up with my own creative identity. Where do we find inspiration for a theme then?

There are many places to visit and be inspired by, sometimes just walking to the shop or going to the park will inspire you. Inspiration can come from anywhere and if you still struggle with this, refer to lesson 1 of Module 3 where we discussed the process of creative thinking.

Ok, so now we know how to approach the process of creating a portfolio and we have some **work** to show off based on the challenges you have done throughout this course. Seeing as these might be some of your first designs created, you might consider more practice in order to get better, or you might want to add more designs **based** on a specific job you are applying for. Alternatively, you can make use of **faux** briefs form fake clients to come up with awesome designs.

Let's say for example you want to apply for a packaging designer role: during this course, we created one packaging mockup, so in order to be even considered for the role of packaging designer, you will need to add more packaging-specific work to your portfolio. I have some great news for you and the aim of this course is to teach you the ins and outs of the graphic design industry. The news is that there are websites that will assist you in building up a portfolio based on an imaginary client brief.

I would like to share three websites that will assist you in growing your portfolio. These websites work on the principle of creating fake client briefs that you can utilise to build your portfolio. Check out http://goodbrief.io/ is amazing if you are very specific about a brief. https://fakeclients.com/ is also another option for generating random design briefs. http://www.whatshouldidesign.com/ is probably the most random of the three - it does not allow you to select the specific industry, but it does help to stir those creative juices.

Consider the following

Now that we have an idea on how our portfolio should look like, how do we know what to add to it? We need to distinguish between relevant and irrelevant work first. Some considerations when compiling your portfolio include:

01. **Showcase only your best work.** Filter through your work and make sure to select only your very best work to add to your portfolio. One tip I can give you here is that if there is any doubt towards an art piece you've created, don't add it. Don't just add content to create a bigger portfolio. Less is more!

02. **Start and end with a strong art piece.** Always begin with a standout piece, a piece that will leave the viewers wanting to see what else is inside your portfolio. Finish with a piece that is strong or even stronger than your first portfolio piece.
03. **Make them want to come back for more.** We want the viewer excited about what they have seen in your portfolio. Depending on the title or job you are looking for, don't add too much of the same design. Make sure you showcase your various skills by adding a variety of different works. Sometimes, showing that you have universal skill can prove to your potential client or employer that you are not a one trick pony but have the ability to adapt with regards to the circumstances thrown at you.

04. **Have an online portfolio.** As a graphic designer it is in your best interest to have an online portfolio. Even if your portfolio is mostly print driven, you can still showcase your work with the aid of digital mock-ups. Refer to the websites we mentioned earlier that allows creatives the ability to share their work.

05. **Let your work speak for itself.** Don't be tempted to overdo it in your portfolio. You don't need an overly designed portfolio, what you need is one with enough white space to breathe and give you work the opportunity to stand out. Design hierarchy is key here.

06. **Tailor your portfolio for the specific role.** Tailor your portfolio to engage with the title which has been advertised. Read through the job spec or consult your potential client and design your portfolio based on this insight. Not only will this showcase only the necessary work, but your potential employer or client will see that you are thorough, which is a soft skill essential for any designer.

07. **Self-created portfolio pieces.** Make sure to flex your creative muscles and work on your own projects. Clients are interested in what you've been working on to determine where your passion lies and what you can achieve without the strict guidelines of a client. The reason for this is it shows your creativity without limits. Personal projects give insight to the type of work you love creating.

08. **Show your design journey.** A project don't just fall from the sky, there was a journey involved. This journey can be translated as the story of the project. It is a good idea to consider adding this story to entice your viewer as it demonstrates the journey as well as your capabilities and skillset.

09. **Format consideration.** Most people think that the traditional print portfolio is an outdated way of approaching interviews. By the time you have reached the interview stage the chances are that you have sent your potential employer your portfolio. However, sometimes, having your work presented as it should be, for example a printed t-shirt, justifies it a lot more than simply viewing a digital mock-up.

10. **Be a confident storyteller.** The key to being successful in an interview is to be confident. Know your design story and be succinct. Don't bore them with unnecessary details. However, don't expect the interviewer to do all the talking as it will show that you are not interested. Your enthusiasm when speaking about your journey as a designer will catch their attention.

Demo: Portfolio creation

The next step after you have found inspiration to your portfolio, is creating it. Based on the research and references you have gathered, you will work according to a theme.

Kevin, who is our design specialist based in Dublin have compiled a really nice demo in illustrating the process of coming up with a design portfolio.

Please refer to video lesson for this demo.

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